

THE DIALECTICAL PHENOMENA AND PROCESSES OF THE MIND

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ABSTRACT

For the last 14 years, the author has been interviewing Tibetan lamas at considerable length about their experiences of their own mind in meditation for the purposes of: 1) developing a formal descriptive science of the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness; and 2) using that descriptive science to describe the defining characteristics of the healthy human mind. This paper will present the central elements of the descriptive science of the stream of consciousness that has been generated by these interviews. It will do so as a means of making the case that the psychological processes that appear in the stream of consciousness have, as a group, a coherent functional identity. This paper will also present representative excerpts from the interviews from which the descriptive science has been derived.

‘Thoughts’ and ‘things’ are names for two sorts of object . . .”

William James, “Does Consciousness Exist?”

Three decades of modern stream of consciousness research have made it possible to conclude that the stream of consciousness is a universal phenomenon [1, 2]. It is a universal phenomenon in the sense that it seems that all healthy human beings experience themselves as having a stream of consciousness: a temporal

sequence of thoughts, images, emotions, and feelings that seem to appear inside one's own mind.

All human beings have red blood cells that contain hemoglobin molecules that carry oxygen to their tissues. All healthy human beings have a four-chambered heart. All human beings have a stream of consciousness.

Singer—a seminal figure in stream of consciousness research—has taken note of the universality of the stream of consciousness in a number of different ways in his writings. For example:

1. There is “considerable data that document(s) the apparent universality of daydreaming . . .” [1, p. 146].
2. “. . . People are almost continuously engaging in thoughts or daydreams that involve judgments about their own traits . . .” [1, p. 168].
3. “We carry on a continuous stream of thought, anticipating or fantasizing a vast range of possible situations or self-representations and trying out mentally a considerable repertory of possible actions” [2, p. 420].

In other words, the stream of consciousness is a universal phenomenon. The present paper is going to build upon this finding by making two additional points: 1) the phenomena that appear *within* the stream of consciousness are also universal phenomena; and 2) these phenomena participate in and mediate a group of psychological processes that are present in all human minds.

This is not to say, by any means, that the *contents* of any one person's stream of consciousness are universal. The case being made here is that all healthy human beings have and experience themselves as having a stream of consciousness, and that this stream of consciousness mediates a distinctive group of psychological processes that occur in all human beings. Common sense and a large body of empirical research seem to indicate that this is, indeed, the case.

THE IDENTITY OF THE PHENOMENA THAT APPEAR IN THE STREAM OF CONSCIOUSNESS

Science has already acknowledged the existence of one group of universal psychological processes: the cognitive processes of the mind. Despite the fact that no one has ever done studies that have sought to demonstrate the universality of the cognitive processes per se, I don't think anyone would question the notion that certain basic cognitive processes are a universal presence in all healthy human minds. All human beings have sensory experiences of the world. All human beings create and recall memories. All human beings learn. And so forth.

This paper is going to make the case that there is a second group of psychological processes that are universally present within the human mind. In so doing, it will also take the position that all of the phenomena and processes that appear in the stream of consciousness have, as a group, a coherent functional identity.

Science has really just begun the task of empirically understanding the human stream of consciousness, and it is the opinion of this paper that we have not yet fully appreciated the functional identity of the phenomena and processes that appear within the stream of consciousness.

Science has attributed more than one identity to these phenomena. One basic tendency has been that of seeing the stream of consciousness as a cognitive process. James [3], of course, took the position that the stream of consciousness is a temporal sequence of thoughts, and in a later paper [4] he took the additional position that thoughts have the function of knowing. In other words, James saw the stream of consciousness as being the cognitive process by which human beings know their world. In his own words:

There is a function in experience which thoughts perform. . . . That function is knowing. "Consciousness" is supposed necessary to explain the fact that things not only are, but get reported, are known [4, p. 477].

James has not been, by any means, alone in seeing the stream of consciousness as cognitive process. Before James, the Introspectionists took the position that the psychological processes that appear in the stream of consciousness are cognitive processes. Wundt and his Structuralist colleagues saw themselves as using introspection to study the cognitive processes of sensation, and the Wurzburg School saw itself as using introspection to study the cognitive processes of imageless thought [5].

More recently, Farthing [6], in his excellent textbook, took the position that eight different kinds of phenomena—most of which are cognitive—appear in the stream of consciousness:

1. Sensory Perceptions
2. Internal Speech—"Thinking in Words"
3. Mental Imagery—"Thinking in Mental Images"
4. Conceptual Thoughts—"Thinking in Terms of Abstract Categories"
5. Memories
6. Emotional Feelings
7. Volition—"The Act of Deciding Upon a Course of Action"
8. Self Awareness—"Being Aware that Your Actions and Experiences Belong to the Person to Whom (Your) Self-Concept Refers"

The second basic hypothesis that modern psychology has developed about the nature of the stream of consciousness has been that of seeing the stream of consciousness as the medium of self-awareness. Farthing, for example, lists self-awareness as the last item in his typology of the contents of the stream of consciousness. Natsoulas [7, 8], in his excellent series of papers on the various concepts of consciousness, has delineated two concepts of consciousness (which he calls C_2 and C_4) that depict the stream of consciousness as being a medium of self-awareness. Singer's research, once again, has led him to the same conclusion.

He sees the stream of consciousness as being a medium in which, “people are almost continuously engaging in thoughts or daydreams about their own actual traits and, quite possibly, how these (traits) relate to ideal or socially expected patterns” [1, p. 168].

DEFINITIONS

The present paper will agree with and build upon this second line of thought. It will refine this second hypothesis by making it more precise, and it will do so by attributing a single functional identity to all of the phenomena and processes that appear in the stream of consciousness. It will recognize the existence of this group of processes by describing them, and it will also attribute an identity to them by giving them a name: the *dialectical processes of the mind*.

The *dialectical processes of the mind* are those processes by which the mind knows, evaluates and controls itself. To be more precise, they are the processes by which the mind: (a) knows and regulates the expression of the thoughts, feelings and emotions that appear in its stream of consciousness; and (b) maintains its sense of identity. The mind accomplishes these ends by having a dialogue, or dialectical relationship if you will, with itself. The dialectical processes include the processes of self awareness—the processes by which the mind knows itself; but as we will be seeing, self awareness is just one aspect of dialectical process.

The *dialectical phenomena of the mind*, in turn, are the phenomena that participate in and mediate the dialectical processes. The dialectical phenomena mediate the dialectical processes in much the same way that electrons, for example, mediate electricity.

In contrast, the *cognitive processes of the mind* are those processes by which the mind knows and gives meaning to its experience of the world. They are the processes by which the mind constructs those experiences and processes the information they contain. The meanings created by cognitive process appear in the stream of consciousness as thoughts, images, feelings and emotions. The *dialectical processes*, in turn, regulate the expression of the meanings created by cognitive process and alter their content.¹

The present paper is going to make the case that the phenomena and processes that appear in the stream of consciousness are the dialectical processes of the mind, and it will do so by presenting a descriptive science of these phenomena and processes. The description of these processes will make it possible to see what

¹Meaning is being defined here as any construct that the mind creates in response to its experience that creates intention. That would include both the dual meanings of the egocentric mind—for example the thoughts and emotions of everyday life with which we are all familiar, and the nondual meanings of the egoless mind. Please see the Appendix on DzogChen at the end of this paper for brief descriptions of some of the nondual meanings. Please see *Volumes III and IV of The Healthy Mind Interviews* as well for a more thorough discussion of several of the nondual meanings [9, 10].

types of things are actually being done by these processes, and this, in turn, will make it possible to see what kind of processes they really are. First, however, let us take a brief look at a body of theory that has already recognized the existence of the dialectical processes of the mind.

UNIVERSALITY AND THE THEORY OF DIALECTICAL PROCESSES

There is, in the history of western ideas, a body of mind theory that has recognized the existence of the dialectical processes of the mind. In so doing, it has discussed these processes as though they are universal processes that exist in the minds of all human beings.

The history of psychology has given us three basic species of mind theory:

1. the metaphysical theories;
2. the cognitive theories; and
3. the dialectical theories.

Each type of theory is defined by the central issue, or issues, that it addresses.

The metaphysical theories are those theories that have been concerned with the central question of determining if mind is a type of matter or something altogether different than matter. The cognitive mind-theories are, of course, those theories that have sought to understand the cognitive processes of the mind.

The dialectical mind-theories are that group of theories that have taken up the task of understanding how the mind knows, relates to, and controls itself. It is these theories that have recognized the existence of the dialectical processes of the mind.

The dialectical theories are usually structural theories of the mind that: (a) divide the mind into several substructures and then (b) depict the mind as being a system in which one or more of these substructures attempts to control the rest of the mind.

For example, Freud's Structural Theory is a dialectical model of the mind in which one part of the mind, the ego, is portrayed as controlling impulses from another part of the mind, the Id, at the behest of the superego [11]. The false-self system controls the self in Laing's phenomenological theory [12]. Reason controls the appetites and passions in the chariot metaphor found in Plato's *Phaedrus* [13], and the mind, or buddhi, controls the senses in a model of the mind that is presented as yet another chariot metaphor in the Katha Upanishad of early Hindu thought [14].

Once again, these are all theories that purport to describe the dynamic by which the mind knows and relates to its own impulses. They are theories that describe and discuss the dialectical processes as though they are processes that are present in all human minds.

Dialectical mind theory, if it is to be empirically valid, must be theory that has been derived from the systematic observation of the dialectical processes of the mind. This follows, of course, from the structure of the scientific method. In our present context, it is worth taking note, for a moment, of the nature of this method.

Classically, there are three stages to the scientific study of any phenomenon; whether it be photosynthesis, hurricanes, or the migratory habits of whales. The first step is to make careful and systematic observations of the phenomenon, or group of phenomena, you wish to understand. The second step is to construct a theory that is derived from and explains your previous observations. The final step is to test and perhaps change your theory by making yet further observations.

Now it turns out that the only way to empirically study the dialectical processes of the mind is to make systematic observations of the stream of consciousness. Why? Because the only place at which a human being can look and actually see, or observe, the dialectical processes of the mind is the stream of consciousness. This is where they occur, and this is where they appear. This is the same as saying that one must look at DNA molecules, as opposed to lipid molecules, to understand the genetic code.

This is also the same as saying what you actually see, when you look at the stream of consciousness, are the dialectical processes of the mind. This means that if science is going to empirically study the dialectical processes of the mind, it will have to allow itself to study the stream of consciousness.

As matters now stand, the literature of western psychology does not yet possess a systematic descriptive science of the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness. Likewise, we do not yet have a theoretical science of the stream of consciousness that has been derived from a systematic descriptive science of those phenomena.²

As a result, science does not yet have an empirical understanding of a group of very important natural phenomena—the dialectical processes of the mind. This has been a large, although understandable, omission, and it is one that we can correct, now that it is becoming apparent that meditation is, among other things, a scientific tool that can be used to empirically study the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness [15-17].

²In contrast, Buddhist psychology does contain a descriptive and theoretical science of the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness. As the next section will begin to show, the stream of consciousness has been, from the very beginning, a central concern of Buddhist mind science. This concern with the stream of consciousness flows directly from the fact that the practice of meditation creates a situation in which a person is confronted with and constantly aware of his or her stream of consciousness.

MEDITATION: A TOOL FOR EMPIRICALLY STUDYING THE PHENOMENA THAT APPEAR IN THE STREAM OF CONSCIOUSNESS

The idea of using meditation to empirically study the stream of consciousness is not, by any means, a new one. Buddhists have been using meditation to develop detailed descriptive phenomenologies of the mind for more than two millennia.

Over the centuries, Buddhist practitioners of meditation have been systematically describing and analyzing the mental phenomena that they experience in meditation. They have done so with a great deal of precision, as it has been a matter of genuine and great import for them. After all, a Buddhist pursues the practice of meditation for the very real and concrete purpose of changing the way his or her mind works. The Buddhists realized early on that they would need to have, in taking on a task of this magnitude, a reliable body of knowledge to help them understand what they were doing.

To meet this need, Buddhists have, throughout their history, used meditation for a second purpose: to make observations of the stream of consciousness as a means of developing a body of knowledge that could be used to guide and inform their practice of meditation [15, 16].

Toward this end, the Buddhists have developed, over the centuries, two fundamentally different types of descriptive phenomenology of the mind. The first one is exemplified by the typology of mental events that is found in the Abhidharma literature [18, 19] of early Buddhism.³ This descriptive psychology is primarily, although not solely, a *content phenomenology* of the mind.

A content phenomenology is a typology of mental phenomena in which each phenomenon is defined by its content. So for example, in the Abhidharmic phenomenology, one phenomenon is defined as anger. A second one is excitement. A third one is equanimity, and so on. This Abhidharmic phenomenology does describe some dialectical phenomena, but it does not present a systematic typology of the dialectical phenomena and processes of the human mind.

The second type of Buddhist phenomenology is a *formal phenomenology* of the mind. A formal phenomenology of the mind is a typology of mental phenomena in which each phenomenon is defined by its structural or dynamic form, as opposed to its content. For example, one phenomenon found in this type of typology is the involuntary stream of consciousness. A second phenomenon is the cessation, or disappearance, of the involuntary stream of consciousness. A third phenomenon is the dissolution of an individual moment of consciousness, and so forth.

³The term Abhidharma refers to an early Buddhist literature that consists of a number of commentaries that were written about the early sutras of Buddhism. Whereas the sutras were dialogues, the Abhidharma texts were written for the purpose of deriving, from those dialogues, a systematic Buddhist philosophy and psychology. The psychology of the Abhidharma literature is one of six different systematic theories of the mind that appear in the history of Buddhist ideas.

There are bits and pieces of formal phenomenology scattered throughout the entire Buddhist literature, and a systematic formal phenomenology of the mind can be found in the DzogChen⁴ literature of Tibetan Buddhism [20-25]. The writings of the 14th century DzogChen scholar Longchenpa, for example, contain a systematic formal phenomenology of the stream of consciousness [20, 21], and this phenomenology is, to my eye, a comprehensive descriptive science of the dialectical phenomena of the mind. A formal descriptive science of these phenomena can be found in many other DzogChen texts as well [22-25].⁵

When I first discovered the DzogChen literature and its systematic descriptions of the dialectical phenomena, it occurred to me that perhaps some, if not all, of these phenomena might actually be universal phenomena that appear in the minds of all human beings. As a first step toward determining whether or not this hypothesis was correct, I began to interview contemporary DzogChen lamas to ascertain if they themselves were actually experiencing the dialectical phenomena described in their literature.

The scope of these interviews has evolved since that time, and for the last 14 years now, I have been systematically interviewing DzogChen lamas who live in the Tibetan diaspora of South and Central Asia. Typically, although not always, I interview a given lama five to ten times. I interview them about their experiences of their own mind in meditation, and I have been doing so for the purposes of:

1. Developing a descriptive science of the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness and
2. Using that descriptive science to describe the defining characteristics of the healthy human mind.

A description of the history and methodology of those interviews can be found in a paper entitled “The Descriptive Mind Science of Tibetan Buddhist Psychology and The Nature of the Healthy Human Mind” [16].

The next several sections of this paper will present a descriptive typology of many of the dialectical phenomena of the mind as they have been described in these lama interviews. This typology is being presented here as evidence in support of the hypothesis that the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness are the phenomena that mediate the dialectical processes by which the mind knows and controls itself.

By way of anticipating and perhaps heading off any potential for confusion, it should be noted that the purpose of the lama interviews has not been that of

⁴There are four main lineages, or sects if you will, within Tibetan Buddhism: the Gelug, Kagyu, Sakya, and Nyingma traditions. The DzogChen literature is the most advanced teachings of the Nyingma sect, and it contains a distinctive mind science and philosophy that are unique, in the history of Buddhist ideas, to the DzogChen tradition.

⁵For a thorough introduction to the DzogChen tradition, and its science of the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind, please see the Appendix on DzogChen at the end of this paper.

demonstrating that the psychological theories of the Tibetan Buddhist tradition are either correct or incorrect. The broader purposes of this body of work have been that of: (a) empirically studying the dialectical processes of the mind and (b) determining the defining characteristics of the healthy human mind [9, 16, 26, 27].

THE EXPERIENCE OF THE DIALECTICAL PHENOMENA OF THE MIND

The basic *structure* of the mind's experience of itself, as one knows it in meditation, is a situation in which the mind's awareness, or mind's eye in common parlance, watches the appearance and disappearance of the phenomena that arise within its stream of consciousness [28, 29].

When the mind knows itself in this dual mode of experience, it actually seems as though two different entities, or minds, are present within that experience.⁶ There is one mind, the stream of consciousness, that presents meanings to the mind's awareness, and there is a second mind, or awareness, that knows and responds to those meanings. It is much the same experience as standing by the side of a river and watching that river flow by. The experience of watching one's mind and having the impression that these two different minds are present is being called the phenomenon of *experiential duality*⁷ in this paper.

We will be calling the two entities that appear within this dualistic experience of the mind the *watcher* and the *stream of consciousness*. The watcher is the awareness that knows and responds to the meanings that appear in the stream of consciousness. The stream of consciousness is the temporal sequence of thoughts, images, emotions, and feelings that appear as the stream of consciousness to the watcher. All of the dialectical phenomena described in this paper are being described as they are known and experienced by the watcher.

The central *dynamic* of intrapsychic experience is one in which two basic things happen: (a) the stream of consciousness presents meanings to the watcher and then (b) the watcher knows and responds to those meanings. The stream of consciousness presents meanings to the watcher in the form of thoughts, images, feelings and emotions, and the watcher can and does respond to these meanings in a number of different ways. For example, the watcher might repress an emotion, hold onto a thought, or do absolutely nothing at all.

Every single response that the watcher makes to a given meaning initiates, in its turn, a causal sequence of events that determines what will happen next to that meaning. Different responses initiate different causal sequences. For example, when the watcher represses an emotion, that emotion will remain present in

⁶As we shall be seeing, the mind can have both dual and nondual awareness of itself.

⁷Experiential duality is related to, but different than, the phenomena of epistemological and/or ontological duality.

awareness as a mood. Or if the watcher attaches, or holds onto, an individual moment of consciousness, it will have dual, as opposed to non-dual, awareness of that moment of consciousness. And so forth.

In keeping with this basic analysis, the dialectical phenomena that appear to the mind's awareness, or inner eye, can be divided into four categories:

1. the phenomena that appear as meanings in the stream of consciousness;
2. the phenomena that appear as responses that the watcher makes to those meanings;
3. the causal phenomena: phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness as a result of the responses that the watcher makes to a given prior phenomenon; and
4. the causal sequences: the causal relationships that exist between the watcher and the stream of consciousness.

In the passages that follow, a number of these phenomena will be defined and described in detail. Once again, they will be described as they are known and experienced by the watcher.

I. Meanings

The stream of consciousness presents meanings to awareness in two fundamental and different forms: (a) as the *involuntary stream of consciousness* (ISoC) and (b) as individual *moments of consciousness* (MoC).

The ISoC is a temporal sequence of thoughts, images, feelings, and emotions. It is involuntary in the sense that the watcher experiences the ISoC as not being under its control. This is true in two regards: one, the ISoC starts and stops of its own accord; and two, the contents of the thoughts and images it contains are not under the voluntary control of the watcher.

It is, in meditation, easy to observe the appearance and disappearance of the ISoC. It is usually observed against the background of an assigned meditative task.

Almost all meditation techniques involve a task in which a mediator is asked to try and keep his or her awareness focused on a single object of some sort. That object might be your breath, the visualized image of a Buddha, the feeling of compassion, or any number of other things.

The ISoC appears against the background of an assigned meditative task—in much the same way that task unrelated images and thoughts (TUITs) have been found to appear in the laboratory study of ongoing conscious thought [30-32]. Klinger [33] has given the name “respondent thoughts” to the ISoC.

Most people are generally unaware of their ISoC before they begin to meditate, but once meditation introduces you to the ISoC, you quickly come to realize that it is almost always active within your mind [7]. The typical experience that a person has, as he or she tries to keep their awareness focused on a meditative object, is that they will find, more often than not, that a garrulous stream of thoughts, images, and

feelings is present within their mind. As a result, they stop attending to their assigned object and can even get lost in their stream of thoughts. It's much the same as sitting in a movie theater and forgetting that you are watching a movie. It happens to everyone who meditates, and it happens a lot. This is the involuntary stream of consciousness.

With the ongoing practice of meditation, the ISoC begins to slow down. The speed and intensity of the involuntary stream seem to decrease, and temporal gaps will actually begin to appear in the ISoC. This slowing of the ISoC is the phenomenon of *diminution*.

As the ISoC slows down and becomes less of a distraction, it becomes apparent that there is, within the mind, a second, more subtle, process that presents meanings to the watcher. If the first process is the ISoC, which presents meanings to awareness in a dream-like sequence of many different thoughts and images, the second process presents meanings to the mind as individual *moments of consciousness* (MoC): as a single thought, a single image, or a single feeling. You do not have to meditate to experience individual MoCs, and they are often experienced by people who are not in the midst of meditating as a quick moment of poetic realization or insight.

There are a number of essential differences between the ISoC and a single MoC. When a single MoC appears in the stream of consciousness, it appears for an instant, and then it quickly dissolves and disappears. After it dissolves, a gap will often appear in the stream of consciousness. That is, a period of time will occur in which thoughts and/or emotions simply do not arise. In contrast, when the ISoC is active, thoughts and emotions just continue to appear one right after another.

Another defining difference between the individual MoC and the ISoC is the way in which they give meaning to a person's experience. An individual MoC seems to give meaning to one specific event—the immediate experience in which a person is involved. A single MoC will tell you how you feel about the string quartet to which you are listening. Or what you want to say to the person standing in front of you. Or how you feel about what it was you just said to that person.

The ISoC, in contrast, does not give meaning to one specific experience. It tends to run for long periods of time, and in so doing, it projects a narrative, or contextual, meaning onto all of the experiences that a person is having during that period of time.

The ISoC creates contextual meaning by telling stories. The narrative of these stories, which I will be calling *mind films* in this paper, is presented, or carried, by the thoughts and images contained in the ISoC.⁸ This happens in much the same way that thoughts and images carry the narrative of a dream. The Tibetan tradition has long recognized the existence of these films, and it

⁸The mind films create narratives, or realities if you will, that support the ego's belief that it has the identity it thinks it has. For this reason, I sometimes use the term "ego narratives" to refer to the mind films.

calls them *baks-chaks*—which is translated into English as “habitual patterns of ego thought.”

When a mind film is present and active within a person’s mind, events in the external world take on meaning by being subsumed into, or becoming part of, the narrative of that film. If an angry film is playing, the mind will tend to give angry meanings to its experience. Passionate films predispose to passionate meanings. Jealous films to jealous meanings, and so forth. It is in this way that the mind films color and give contextual meaning to the mind’s experience of the world.

II. Responses

The mind can and does respond to the meanings that appear in the stream of consciousness in a number of different ways. Awareness, or the watcher, experiences itself as being the source of these responses, and some of those responses are as follows:

1. repression;
2. attachment;
3. following;
4. detachment; and
5. empty awareness.

Repression and Attachment

Repression is the process by which the mind tries to keep itself from becoming aware of a meaning that appears in its stream of consciousness. The watcher represses MoCs and ISOc-films that it does not like by keeping them away from that place in the intrapsychic space at which it is located.

The phenomenon of *attachment* is just the opposite. It is the process by which the watcher holds onto and keeps present in awareness meanings that it likes. For example, if the watcher attaches a good feeling, it will remain in awareness as a good mood. If the watcher attaches a flattering thought, that thought will become a sequence of flattering thoughts that remain present in awareness as a flattering mind film.

Following and Detachment

The watcher responds to the content of a mind film in two fundamental ways: *following* and *detachment*. When the mind follows a film, it believes and lives in the narrative reality contained in that film. When the mind detaches from a film, it does not believe and/or live in its story.

When the mind follows a film, it believes it in the sense that (a) the watcher believes the narrative of the story being portrayed by the film is real; and (b) the watcher participates in, and is thus not separate from, the mood of the film. The

viewer finds itself immersed in that mood, and that the mood actually colors its experience of both itself and the external world.

When the mind is detached from a film, just the opposite happens. It does not believe that film in the sense that: (a) the viewer does not believe the story contained in the film's thoughts and images; and (b) the viewer experiences itself as being separate, or detached, from the mood of the film. As a result, the film and its mood do not color the mind's experience.

Empty Awareness

Empty awareness is a state of mind in which the mind's awareness does not respond in any way to the meanings that appear in its stream of consciousness. It does not repress, attach, follow, or alter them in any way, and in so doing, it refrains from projecting any conceptual overlay onto those meanings. As a result, it knows the contents of those meanings exactly as they are.

In essence, empty awareness allows the stream of consciousness to remain in its natural state and pursue its own natural course. In this state of empty awareness, the viewer is, in a very real sense, like a space through which the stream of consciousness flows unimpeded. For this reason, I sometimes use the term *space-like awareness* as a synonym for empty awareness.

III. Causal Phenomena

The different responses that the viewer makes to the meanings that appear in the stream of consciousness each have an effect on those phenomena. Each type of response causes a well-defined and distinctive change to occur in the stream of consciousness. These changes are observable, and they occur in a regular fashion.

In general, each and every response that the viewer makes to a meaning that appears in the stream of consciousness can and will affect that phenomenon in two fundamental ways:

1. it will determine whether the viewer has dual or nondual awareness of that meaning; and
2. it will determine whether or not that meaning will be transformed into a mind film or dissolve and disappear.

When the viewer represses, attaches or follows a meaning—whether it be an MoC or an ISoC film—it will cause itself to have *dual awareness* of that meaning. When the viewer has empty awareness of a meaning, it will have *non-dual awareness* of that meaning.

By way of defining *dual awareness*, it is, at a descriptive level, a moment of awareness in which a subject and object exist and remain separate from one another. In the dual awareness of a thought, for example, a thought appears in the stream of consciousness, and the viewer experiences itself as being an entity that is spatially and ontologically separate from that thought.

Nondual awareness, on the other hand, is experienced as a moment of awareness in which the separation, or duality, between a subject and object quite literally disappears. This happens because the watcher experiences the non-dual awareness of any meaning as the phenomenon of *dissolution*: a meaning appears in the stream of consciousness, and then it immediately dissolves and disappears into awareness.

The import of nondual awareness is that when the mind has nondual awareness of a meaning, it knows the content of that meaning exactly as-it-is; which is the same as saying that it knows that meaning without projecting any additional meanings, or constructs, onto it. When the mind has nondual awareness of itself, it knows itself as-it-is.

In contrast, when the mind has dual awareness of an individual meaning, it does project additional constructs onto that meaning. As a result, the mind does not know that meaning as it is. For example, when the watcher has dual awareness of a single MoC, its knowledge of that MoC will be a mixture of MoC and projected construct. By way of illustration, the watcher might, in the dual awareness of a MoC, experience that MoC in combination with an emotion or a mind film.

On the other hand, when the mind has a nondual awareness of a meaning, whether it be a MoC or an ISoC mind film, that meaning will be transformed into a different phenomenon. There are four different ways that a meaning can be transformed by nondual awareness, and each type of transformation produces a different kind of phenomenon. Collectively, this paper will be calling these metamorphoses the *nondual transformations*, and they will be described at length in this very next section.

The Nondual Transformations

The first nondual transformation is the phenomenon of *dissolution*, which has just been described: thoughts and emotions appear to the mind's eye and then they simply and immediately dissolve and disappear.

All three of the remaining nondual transformations begin with a dissolution. In each of these transformations, the dissolution of a meaning occurs first, and then it is followed by the appearance of a new, or second, phenomenon.

Consider, for example, the phenomenon of *realization*, which is another type of nondual transformation. Realization starts off with the dissolution of a meaning. After that first dissolution has occurred, a deep insight into one's own nature and/or the nature of the universe arises spontaneously. The person having the insight feels at peace and as though he or she has gained an understanding of something important.

A third type of nondual transformation is the phenomenon of *amused compassion*. In this phenomenon, the meaning that dissolves is transformed into the feeling of compassion. It is experienced like this: First, the meaning dissolves, and as it dissolves you become aware of its content and see that it is a bit foolish.

Somehow, in the act of seeing that meaning as-it-is, you spontaneously understand and accept it, and a feeling of amused compassion arises in place of the original meaning.

The fourth nondual transformation is the phenomenon of *nondual joy*. In this phenomenon, a MoC is transformed into a feeling of psychological and physical joy. The experience develops in much the same way as the phenomenon of compassion. A MoC arises. Nondual awareness of that MoC occurs, and as it dissolves, joy arises in its stead.

THE LAMA INTERVIEWS

This next section of the paper is going to present a few brief passages from interviews that have been done with two different lamas over the years of this project. They are being presented here for the purposes of: (a) giving you an idea of how these interviews generate data; and (b) providing you with some of the actual data that has generated the central hypothesis being presented in this paper. That hypothesis, once again, is that the psychological processes that appear in the stream of consciousness are the dialectical processes of the mind. The excerpts presented here have been taken from interviews that were done with the following lamas: Chosje Rinpoche and Lopon Tekchoke.

Chosje Rinpoche

In this passage, Chosje Rinpoche describes the basic structure of the mind's experience of itself in meditation, and he then goes on to use that basic structure as a foundation from which to describe some of the fundamental phenomena and mechanics of the egocentric mind. I interviewed Chosje Rinpoche four times in the Kingdom of Ladakh⁹ in the summer of 1998.

HMV: When you meditate, does a stream of thoughts ever appear in your mind?

CJR: Yes.

HMV: How do the thoughts appear? Do they enter in your mind as images?

CJR: Yes.

HMV: Do they ever appear as words?

CJR: Yes.

HMV: Do they ever appear as emotions?

⁹Ladakh is a Buddhist kingdom located on the western edge of the Tibetan plateau. It was an independent kingdom until it was conquered by an Indian prince in the middle of the 19th century. As a result, it is now part of the Indian state of Jammu and Kashmir.

CJR: Yes.

HMV: Do they ever appear as feelings?

CJR: Yes.

HMV: Are there other kinds of appearances as well?

CJR: All kinds of phenomenal experience. There is no limit to what will arise and what will not arise. It can be feeling. It can be emotion. It can be trying to think that red is yellow and yellow is red. (Laughter)

HMV: Is this stream of thoughts involuntary? That is, do you have the feeling that you make those thoughts appear, or do they appear on their own?

CJR: They just appear.

HMV: Do you choose the contents of those thoughts, or does the content choose itself?

CJR: If you know how to make your mind open, then it will come like a wave and dissolve by itself. But if you try to observe more than is necessary, you will start to make up all sorts of things. Then you will make a pattern and start to create certain past habits or past thoughts. Or try to fit that with the future. Then we can just create a movie. It's like being at a movie.

HMV: There are movies in the mind aren't there.

CJR: Yes. We can make a whole movie.

HMV: And when a movie comes, do you have the feeling that you are in control of its content?

CJR: When you make a movie, you are not really in control.

HMV: Yes. That's the way it seems to me too.

CJR: You are not in control. But we create a reference point and pretend we are in control, and that's what ego is all about. The ego thinks it's in control, but it's not really in control.

HMV: Why is the ego trying to control the mind?

CJR: Because ego is not real to begin with, and we try to make it real. All of our experience in life is constantly changing, but ego doesn't want it to change. So it tries to solidify its experience.

HMV: Thank you very much. Now let's go back to the stream of consciousness for a moment. In your experience, does the stream of thoughts ever disappear?

CJR: Yes it can disappear.

HMV: How long does it disappear? Seconds? Minutes? Hours? Days? Months?

CJR: Sometimes it can be short time. Sometimes it can be long time.

HMV: And again, is all of this observable?

CJR: Yes. You know it.

HMV: Now. When the stream of thoughts appears in your mind, does it seem like there is an awareness that is watching the thoughts, a watcher?

CJR: Yes there is.

HMV: Would it be fair to say that in this situation where the watcher watches the stream of thoughts, that it seems like there is a duality of subject and object.

CJR: Yes.

HMV: That the object is the thoughts and the subject is the watcher.

CJR: Right. That's the experience. But in one way we know that the watcher and the watching are both none other than our mind. They are not really two. But it seems to be there is a watcher and watching. And instead of being in a non-dual state, we spend years watching the watcher and the watching. (Laughter) Which is an experience. One is trapped in experience. So one needs to know how to meditate to cut through those delusions.

HMV: When you are watching the stream of thoughts, does it ever seem to you that the watcher acts upon, or responds to, the stream of thoughts? For example, does the watcher ever grasp¹⁰ thoughts?

CJR: Yes.

HMV: Is that a fair way to put it? Is it true that within the experience of this apparent duality of watcher and stream of consciousness that the watcher sometimes grasps thoughts?

CJR: Yes. The watcher grasps thoughts. The watcher grasps projections. And actually they are both thoughts.

HMV: The subject and the object are both thoughts.

CJR: Yes. Both subject and object. The watcher grasps the projection and the projection is a thought.

HMV: Does the watcher ever reject a thought?

¹⁰Grasp" is a technical term in Buddhist psychology. To grasp a thought, or for that matter any other meaning that appears in the stream of consciousness, is to know that thought by attributing a concept of self to it. The watcher is the entity that grasps the meanings that appear in the stream of consciousness. DzogChen mind science says that the watcher grasps thoughts whenever it takes one of three basic types of action: (a) rejecting or repressing a thought; (b) accepting, or holding onto, a thought; and (c) following, or believing the narrative theme of, a stream of thoughts. Whenever the watcher grasps a thought or meaning, it has dual awareness of that meaning. The Tibetan term that is translated as grasp is "dzinpa."

CJR: Sure. It will reject something unpleasant. It will also accept something pleasant.

HMV: Does it ever follow thoughts?

CJR: It will do that, and it will also let all of them go.

HMV: And you can experience all of that.

CJR: Absolutely. When you accept your experience, you experience the whole thing. When you reject your experience, you experience the whole thing. And when you let go, you can also experience the whole thing. (Laughter)

HMV: How does the watcher experience the phenomenon of rejection? How would you describe that experience?

CJR: The watcher is not a neutral state. You see. Basically the watcher takes sides. All of the watcher's rejection and accepting is ego process.

HMV: Ok. So that's all ego.

CJR: Yes. It's all ego process.¹¹

HMV: Why does the ego accept, reject and follow thoughts that appear in its stream of consciousness?

CJR: There are things that feel pleasant. There are things that feel unpleasant. Accepting. Rejecting.

HMV: Does the watcher in the mind with an ego reject thoughts that are inconsistent, or disagree with, its self-image or self-concept?

CJR: Oh sure. Sometimes you try to work against your habitual thought patterns. Yes. It could definitely play that trick.

HMV: Now on the other hand, could the watcher accept, or hold onto, those thoughts or inner appearances that support its picture of itself?

CJR: Absolutely. It does that most of the time. (Laughter) Much more than it does the other one. (Laughter) Most of the time it will try to work how it wants to be.

HMV: The ego is very busy, is it not?

Lopon Tekchoke

The distinction between the egoless and egocentric mind is an important one in Tibetan psychology. Tibetan psychological theory holds that an egoless, or

¹¹In general, Tibetan psychology defines the ego as having two basic components: (a) a concept of self; and (b) the constructs, or delusions, that the egocentric mind creates to maintain that concept of self. Here, Chosje Rinpoche is using the term "ego process" to refer to the second component—the processes by which the egocentric mind creates and sustains the delusion that it has an identity.

nondual, mind is a healthy and happy mind. It also holds that the egocentric, or dual, mind is an unhappy and unhealthy mind. Tibetan psychology sees the egocentric mind as being a mind that is at war with itself, and as being a mind that is caught up in dysfunctional narratives and moods created by the ego.

In its efforts to understand and cultivate the egoless mind, Tibetan psychology has tended to focus on seeing the egoless mind as a specific mode of awareness; as a specific mode of nondual self-awareness, to be more precise. The agent of nondual awareness, if you will, is called “rigpa” in DzogChen mind science.

Tibetan psychology has also found it important to recognize that different kinds of meanings appear in the streams of consciousness of the egocentric and egoless mind. Dual meanings appear in the egocentric stream of consciousness, and they appear as the thoughts, emotions and recurring ego narratives that are being called “mind films” in this paper. Nondual meanings can also appear, and they appear in the egoless stream of consciousness.

In the passage that follows, Lopon Tekchoke, a Bhutanese lama who lives and teaches in both Bhutan and Sikkim, will describe and discuss in detail one type of nondual meaning that appears in the egoless stream of consciousness. The type of meaning he describes is being called “timeless wisdom” here, which is a translation of the technical Tibetan term “day khona yid togpai yeshe.” This phenomenon was referred to as a “realization” in the typology of phenomena presented above. I have interviewed Lopon Tekchoke a total of eight times in both Sikkim and Bhutan over the last six years.

HMV: There are times when countless thoughts are running through my mind. The thoughts come and go one right after another. At other times, there are long interludes in which there are but a few thoughts coming and going. During these periods of relative quiet, I become increasingly aware of the appearance of subtler single thoughts in my mind that appear and then instantly dissolve and disappear just like that (I snap my fingers).

LTC: All that time, you are on the path.

HMV: It has been my experience, that four different kinds of phenomena¹² can, and consistently do, appear immediately after a single thought dissolves like that. Sometimes, for example, a feeling of joy will arise after a single thought dissolves. Sometimes the feeling of compassion will appear. Sometimes there will be a temporary cessation of all inner appearances; a single thought will dissolve and then nothing new will arise for a period of time.

LTC: Yes.

HMV: The fourth thing that can and does happen after the dissolution of a single thought, is that a large insight of one kind or another will immediately

¹²The four phenomena being referred to here are the four “nondual transformations” that were described above in the section entitled “The Experience of the Dialectical Phenomena of the Mind.”

arise within my mind. It might be an understanding of the nature of mind, or perhaps an understanding of nondual awareness. It could be any number of things.

LTC: That insight is timeless wisdom; enlightened mind.

HMV: Do you mean to say that it would be enlightened mind if those insights were present all of the time, as opposed to just coming and going for moments at a time?

LTC: Yes. The enlightened mind is a permanent chain of nondual moments. If you are in the dharmakaya,¹³ there are no thoughts.¹⁴ It is like the permanent nature of the sky. There is a permanent stream of nondual moments.

HMV: Does that mean that the enlightened mind is a permanent stream of nondual moments of timeless wisdom?

LTC: Yes.

HMV: Thank you. That's very helpful. Given that these temporary moments of insight are not enlightened mind, what would you call them? Are they simply moments of timeless wisdom?

LTC: Yes. Initially, timeless wisdom lasts for a very short while. Gradually, as you go on practicing, the primordial wisdom, the gap, increases. At the same time, the deluded minds¹⁵ will decrease. When you reach Buddhahood, then the deluded appearances will cease altogether.

HMV: Then only timeless wisdom and the different aspects of nondual awareness itself will appear.

LTC: Yes. (Emphatic) When the recurring patterns of ego thought¹⁶ are no longer being created, the delusions of the samsaric mind will, over time, gradually subside. And then the timeless wisdom will increase.

HMV: Would be correct to say Lupon, that on the path,¹⁷ in between these moments of timeless wisdom, that thoughts and emotions continue to appear?

¹³“Dharmakaya” is a technical Sanskrit term in Buddhism, and in its traditional philosophical usage, it is one of the three bodies, or aspects, of a Buddha. Empirically, it is one of the three primary attributes of the egoless, or nondual, mind. It is the total openness of nondual awareness.

¹⁴When Lupon Tekchoke says here that there are no thoughts in the egoless mind, he is only saying that there are no dual thoughts. He is not, by any means, saying that nondual meanings do not appear in the egoless mind. Please see Volume III of *The Healthy Mind Interviews* [9] for an empirical discussion by Lupon Tekchoke of three types of nondual meaning.

¹⁵By deluded minds, Lupon means dual, or egocentric, meanings. That would include, once again, the thoughts, emotions, moods and recurring patterns of ego thought of the dual, or egocentric, mind.

¹⁶Once again, the term “recurring patterns of ego thought” is the same phenomenon that is being called “mind films” by both Chosje Rinpoche and the terminology of this paper.

¹⁷“On the path” here, refers to that period of time during which a person is trying to cultivate an egoless mind. A person is said to be “on the path” when he or she is trying to cultivate, but has not yet succeeded in attaining, a stable, or relatively permanent, egoless mind.

LTC: Yes.

HMV: But that once timeless wisdom becomes permanent, thoughts and emotions no longer appear in the mind?

LTC: Yes. That's correct. You have thought it out very well.

HMV: Now, does timeless wisdom always appear as a large insight? Or can it appear in some other way as well?

LTC: Timeless wisdom is always an insight like that. While you are on the path, timeless wisdom has to be continuously appearing. They are essential.

HMV: Why?

LTC: To attain enlightenment. That is the path.

HMV: Is it true, then, that one progresses along the path to enlightenment by having increasingly frequent moments of primordial wisdom?

LTC: Yes.

HMV: How does the realization of these moments of primordial wisdom help a person develop egoless awareness?

LTC: You have yet to see the essence of nondual awareness, or rigpa, face to face. On the path, you still believe you have a self. The sole responsibility of primordial wisdom is to destroy the ignorance created by conceptions of self.

HMV: Ah.

LTC: Nondual awareness and timeless wisdom clean off the dirt of self conception.

HMV: How does timeless wisdom cleanse the mind of the ignorance of self conception?

LTC: Timeless wisdom is actually nondual, or egoless, awareness. When nondual awareness appears, ignorance decreases; it gradually dissolves and disappears.

HMV: Let's try an example. I think of myself as having many different identities, or self concepts, to which I am attached. For example, I see myself as a doctor. I see myself as a mountaineer. I see myself as a person that has a big heart. And so forth. Now when you say that the ignorance of self conception decreases with the realization of moments of timeless wisdom, are you saying that in a moment of timeless wisdom that a person abandons one of their identities?

LTC: Oh yes. (Emphatic)

HMV: So let's say that maybe I carry around fifty identities. Are you saying that as a result of having an experience of timeless wisdom, that I will let one of those identities go; that in my heart, I will really let one of them go.

LTC: Oh yes.

HMV: And then there are forty-nine more to go.

LTC: Oh yes. (Laughter) It's like this. When you go into the mountains, when you are at the base camp, at that time you are a doctor. Now when you climb the first step, you abandon the doctor at the base. When you climb another step, you get further away from being that doctor. As you go higher and higher up the mountain, the doctor you abandoned at the base camp is farther and farther away. So as your timeless wisdom increases, a given conception of self is abandoned more and more.

HMV: Thank you very much.

CONCLUSIONS

Careful consideration of both the interviews and the typology of the dialectical phenomena and processes presented above, makes it clear that the psychological processes that appear in the stream of consciousness are the processes by which the mind knows and controls itself. What one actually sees, in looking at these phenomena and processes, is the fundamental dynamic that exists between the watcher and the stream of consciousness. It is a dynamic in which one aspect of the mind, the watcher, knows, responds to, and tries to control another aspect of the mind—the meanings that appear to it as the stream of consciousness.

Three pieces of data from the descriptive science of the dialectical phenomena indicate that this is the case. First of all, when one looks at the stream of consciousness, it becomes apparent that it is the means by which the mind presents meanings to the watcher. It presents meanings to the watcher in two fundamental forms: as individual moments of consciousness (MoCs) and as the involuntary stream of consciousness (ISoC).

Secondly, one can also see that the watcher responds to these meanings in a number of different ways, and that each of these different responses initiates, in its turn, causal sequences that transform and determine the fate of those meanings.

Finally, when you take a look at the nature of the responses that the watcher makes to the stream of consciousness, it becomes apparent that the watcher is trying to control the stream of consciousness. The watcher represses some meanings. It attaches others, and it also creates inner narratives that support its sense of identity.

THE TWO MODES OF SELF AWARENESS

But the control dynamic described here is not the entire story. It turns out that the human mind actually has two modes of dialectical processes: an egocentric

mode of self awareness and an egoless mode of self awareness. Each mode of self awareness is a different type of relationship between the watcher and the stream of consciousness, and the control dynamic described above is a partial description of one of these modes of self awareness: the egocentric mode.

Each of the two modes of self awareness has three defining characteristics:

1. a defining purpose;
2. a distinctive repertoire of responses that the watcher makes to the meanings that appear in its stream of consciousness; and
3. the distinctive type of awareness the watcher has of those meanings.

The egocentric mode of self awareness is a Sisyphean dynamic that takes as its purpose the endless task of trying to maintain its sense of identity. It is the watcher that maintains the egocentric mind's identity, and it does so by controlling, in every moment, both the content of the meanings that appear in its stream of consciousness and their expression. As a result, a conflict of intention arises between the watcher and the stream of consciousness.

The descriptive science of the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind describes the three fundamental processes by which the egocentric watcher attempts to preserve its identity:

1. the egocentric watcher represses meanings that are inconsistent with its sense of self;
2. it attaches thoughts and emotions that are consistent with its identity; and
3. it creates and lives in inner narratives that support that sense of identity.

These are the defining behaviors of the egocentric watcher, and when the watcher responds in any one of these ways to a meaning that appears in its stream of consciousness, it causes itself to have dual, and thus distorted, awareness of that meaning. As a result, the egocentric mind does not know itself as it is.

In the context of systems theory, these egocentric processes are the self-regulatory mechanisms of the mind. They are the processes by which the egocentric mind maintains a steady state, and the steady state that is maintained by the watcher is its conception of itself, or its identity. In the context of Psychoanalytic theory, the dialectic of egocentric self awareness can be seen as an empirical rendering of the dynamic that is described by the structural model of Psychoanalytic thought.

The second mode of self awareness is the egoless mode, and it is very different than the egocentric mode. For one, the egoless mind does attempt to maintain its sense of identity. This means that the egoless watcher does not repress, attach, or follow any of the meanings that appear in its stream of consciousness, and that in so doing, it remains in a constant state of empty awareness. As a result, the egoless

watcher has nondual awareness of the meanings it knows, and it knows them as they are. The purpose of egoless self awareness is self realization.¹⁸

In addition, the egoless mind leaves itself in its natural state, and as a consequence of doing so, there is no conflict, or dialectic if you will, between the egoless watcher and its stream of consciousness. The import of leaving the stream of consciousness in its natural state is that it allows the phenomena of the egocentric mind to be spontaneously transformed into the meanings and awareness of the egoless mind. This transformation is called self liberation in DzogChen mind science, and it is the defining dynamic of DzogChen meditation.¹⁹ It is also the means by which the egoless mind controls itself.

PARADOX: THE TWO SPECIES OF MIND KNOWLEDGE

These insights into the nature of these phenomena bring us, in turn, to the unavoidable conclusion that the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness are paradoxical phenomena. They are paradoxical in the sense that every single phenomenon that appears in the stream of consciousness is simultaneously an objective and subjective phenomenon.

On the one hand, every thought and emotion that appears in the stream of consciousness is a construct that contains content that gives meaning to the mind's experience of both itself and the world. As constructs created by the mind, they are, by definition, subjective phenomena.

The meanings that a given mind attributes to an experience are not universal phenomena; different human beings can and do, of course, give different meaning to the same experience. Therefore, to know the *content* of your thoughts and feelings is to know them as subjective phenomena, and, as such, it is a means of acquiring self knowledge—knowledge of the contents of one's own mind.

On the other hand, every single phenomenon that appears in the stream of consciousness is also an objective entity. They are objective in the sense that they are phenomena that participate in and mediate the dialectical processes of the mind—a group of natural processes that are, if the central hypothesis of this paper is correct, processes that are universally present in all human minds.

¹⁸This theory of the two modes of self awareness is one of the more important theories that is being generated by the empirical study of the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness. As I did not want to leave the impression that there is only one mode of self awareness, I have mentioned it here briefly even though it is not the central concern of this paper. For further discussion of the two modes of self awareness, please see the Appendix on DzogChen mind science at the end of this paper, and Volume IV of *The Healthy Mind Interviews* [10]. For a systematic discussion of the two modes of self awareness, please see a forthcoming paper entitled "*The Defining Characteristics of the Healthy Human Mind*"[34].

¹⁹The process of self liberation will also be discussed at greater length in the Appendix on DzogChen at the end of this paper.

To know the *form and function* of the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness is to know them as objects—as the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind. To know them as objects, is to know them as phenomena that can be empirically studied by science.

In keeping with this distinction, it seems that there are two different kinds of knowledge that one can have of the stream of consciousness. On the one hand, there is *subjective knowledge* of the stream of consciousness—which is knowledge of the *content* of your thoughts, inner images feelings, and emotions. On the other hand, there is *objective knowledge* of the stream of consciousness—which is empirical knowledge of the *form and function* of the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind.

THE FIELD OF DESCRIPTIVE PSYCHOLOGY

There have been, in the history of ideas, two bodies of psychological thought that have taken up the task of systematically understanding the dialectical processes of the mind. First of all, there are the depth psychologies of the west—which would include the various schools of Psychoanalytic thought and the Analytic Psychology of Jung. For the most part, the different depth psychologies have all developed, and had at their heart, theories that describe the processes by which the mind relates to and controls itself (e.g., [35-38]). It is important to note that these western theories of dialectical processes have been theories that were derived from the observation of dreams, clinical symptoms, childhood development, and the transference phenomena of the therapeutic process.

The second systematic psychology that has addressed the dialectical processes of the mind is the mind science found in the DzogChen tradition of the Tibetan Buddhist and Bön religions.²⁰ DzogChen psychology contains both a descriptive and theoretical science of the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind [20-25]. In contrast to the theories of depth psychology, the DzogChen theory of dialectical process is a theory that has been derived from the observation of the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness.

Despite the relative strengths of these two very different bodies of thought, they do not have the capacity, even when taken together, to empirically establish that the psychological processes that appear in the stream of consciousness are the dialectical processes of the mind. Each of these psychologies has, in this particular

²⁰The Bön religion is the indigenous religion of the Tibetan plateau. For historical reasons that are not yet entirely understood, Tibetan Buddhism and Bön both possess a DzogChen tradition. Until recently, Western scholars have more or less assumed that: (1) the DzogChen tradition took its origin in the Nyingma sect of Tibetan Buddhism, and that at some later point (2) the Bön religion assimilated DzogChen from the Nyingma tradition after Buddhism came to the Tibetan plateau in the seventh century A.D. But the Bön religion claims that its DzogChen tradition has a different and earlier origin, and that it came from Persia by way of the Swat region of what is now Pakistan. At this point in time, we do not yet have enough data to determine which of these two theories is historically correct.

scientific context, a different weakness. DzogChen mind science, even though it is brimming with observations and valid inference, is found in a religious body of literature. The psychoanalytic literature, on the other hand, does not possess a systematic body of observations of the stream of consciousness.

Furthermore, despite the fact that the body of research presented in this paper has been going on for more than 14 years, it is still embryonic. Replications and additional studies will have to be done to develop a body of data that will be robust enough to establish the validity of the hypothesis that the stream of consciousness is dialectical process.

This need for additional data is one of at least two reasons that it would be useful to establish an area of research that would focus on doing descriptive and theoretical studies of the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness. The second major incentive for taking up the systematic empirical study of the stream of consciousness is that it would open the door to scientifically investigating the dialectical issues of the mind.

By dialectical issue, I mean any specific question that can be most directly answered by empirically studying the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind. Here are a few examples of what seem to me to be dialectical issues:

1. What are the defining characteristics of a healthy mind?
2. What is the best way to cultivate a healthy mind?
3. What role do the mind-rituals²¹ play in cultivating a healthy mind?
4. How do the various mind-rituals change the structural and dynamic characteristics of the mind? How, for example, how do brief term therapy, meditation and the various shamanic rituals alter the mind?
5. What is the function of the stream of consciousness?
6. What are the dialectical causes of psychiatric illness, as opposed to its biological and social causes?
7. What role do the dialectical processes play in generating the symptoms of psychiatric illness?
8. What is the healthiest approach to treating psychiatric symptoms? Is it best to control them? Or is it possible and/or desirable to transform them into the healthy impulses of which they are a distorted expression?
9. What are the neurobiological correlates of the dialectical phenomena and processes? And so on.

Toward the end of encouraging and organizing the empirical study of the dialectical processes and issues of the mind, I have been proposing [16], that a new

²¹A mind ritual is any ritual that is used to change the structural and dynamic properties of the mind. Free association, cognitive therapy, hypnosis, meditation, the Khalahari Kung Fire Dance and the Vision Quest of the Plains Indian are, e.g., mind rituals. There are four categories of mind ritual: rituals of catharsis, rituals of identification, rituals of transformation and rituals of transcendence.

area of research—the field of descriptive psychology—be established within the field of psychology.

Scientists in this area would be both western and indigenous practitioner-scholars who have received extensive theoretical and applied training in meditation. They would use meditation as a research tool, and they would do so for the purposes of:

1. developing a descriptive science of the stream of consciousness;
2. doing research on the dialectical processes and issues of the mind; and
3. developing a body of theory that would be derived from the research.

Like all scientific fields, the field of descriptive psychology would study sensory phenomena. Descriptive psychology would be the field that studies the sensory phenomena that are observed with the sixth, or mental, sense—the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness.

The epistemological structure of the field of descriptive psychology would be analogous to the epistemological structure of the field of elementary particle physics or, for that matter, any other scientific field of enquiry. Most of us, for example, do not know how to use particle accelerators, or how to interpret the events that occur in gas diffusion chambers. Nonetheless, we trust the findings of those physicists who do use them because we know that there is a community of elementary particle physicists working together to assess the validity of one another's work.

The situation would be much the same in a community of scientists using mediation as a research tool. Descriptive psychologists, like scientists in any other field, would assess the validity of one another's findings by replicating their colleagues' work and by discussing their research with one another. They would share their findings in journals and at conferences, and in that way validity and consensus could be established. It would be this dialogue within the field that would: (a) accomplish the interpersonal verification of observations of the stream of consciousness; and (b) establish the validity or invalidity of a piece of research.

It seems to me that the best way to establish that the empirical study of the individual phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness is a valid science is to actually go ahead and do the work that will demonstrate that this is the case. If the resulting work is found to be good and useful by the scientific community, it will stand. If, in contrast, that work is found to be flawed, it will not survive. It is in this spirit that I have presented the data and hypotheses contained in this paper.

APPENDIX: DZOGCHEN MIND SCIENCE

DzogChen is the name of a distinct school of Tibetan Buddhist mind science and meditation. Like all schools of Buddhist practice, DzogChen is grounded in the

notion that the psychological cause of all human suffering is the ego.²² That would include the everyday sufferings of intrapsychic conflict, the larger tragedies of war and everything in between. In keeping with this analysis, the goal of the DzogChen path is to cultivate an egoless mind, given the paradox that you have to have an ego to be egoless.²³

DzogChen is actually the defining view and practice of two different Tibetan religions: the Nyingma sect of Tibetan Buddhism and the indigenous religion of Tibet, the Bön religion.²⁴ Elements of DzogChen practice can also be found in two of the other major sects of Tibetan Buddhism.²⁵

There are two fundamental aspects of the DzogChen tradition that make it unique in relation to the other schools of Tibetan Buddhist practice: (a) the basic dynamic of its meditation techniques; and (b) its view of the mind.

The DzogChen view is unique in that it is, at its heart, an empirical psychology that describes and analyzes the mind's experience of itself as it is known in meditation. This is important because it means that the DzogChen literature is neither a speculative psychology nor an abstract philosophy, as other schools of Buddhism sometimes tend to be. DzogChen mind science actually describes the experiences of the mind that a person has in meditation, and, in so doing, it gives a mediator the knowledge he or she needs to understand and transform those experiences.

Given that the experiences of meditation are experiences in which the mind knows itself, DzogChen psychology is a descriptive and theoretical science of human self awareness. As such, it is both a basic and applied science of how the mind knows and controls itself.

²²The term ego has a different meaning in Tibetan mind science than it does in western psychiatry and psychology. The Tibetan term that gets translated into English as ego is "dag-dzin," which actually gives you the Tibetan definition of the term. "Dag" means identity, and "dzin" means grasping, or attachment. Tibetan mind science sees the mind with an ego as being a mind that: (a) has an identity and that (b) grasps at, or is attached to, that identity. The egocentric watcher grasps, or preserves, its identity by repressing, attaching and following its thoughts and emotions, as has been described in the "Two Modes of Self Awareness" section.

²³It should be quickly mentioned here that not all of the lamas that I have interviewed define the egoless mind as being a state of mind in which a person has an identity. There is a difference of opinion on the matter, and I would like to think that this is an issue that can be resolved empirically. For a discussion of the role of identity in the egoless mind, please see the interview with His Holiness the Dalai Lama in Volume IV of *The Healthy Mind Interviews* [10].

²⁴Once again, for historical reasons that are not yet entirely understood, Tibetan Buddhism and the Bön religion both possess a DzogChen tradition. Please see footnote #21.

²⁵Once again, Tibetan Buddhism has four major lineages, or sects if you will—the Nyingma, Kagyu, Sakya and Gelug traditions—and DzogChen is the primary approach to practice of the Nyingma tradition. Elements of DzogChen practice are also found in the Kagyu and Gelug sects. For example, DzogChen practices are found in three of the subsects of the Kagyu tradition: the Karma Kagyu lineage, the Drikung Kagyu lineage, and the Drugpa Kagyu lineage. In addition, all of the Dalai Lamas since the time of the fifth Dalai Lama—who are the head lamas of the Gelug sect—have been students and practitioners of DzogChen. The present Dalai Lama, for example, has written an excellent book on DzogChen [25].

The most fundamental tenet of DzogChen mind science is that the human mind has two modes of self awareness: an egocentric mode and an egoless mode. The egocentric mind possesses and is defined by the egocentric mode of self awareness. The egoless mind possesses and is defined by the egoless mode of self awareness. DzogChen mind science calls these two modes of self awareness “sems” and “rigpa” respectively. “Sems” means dual mind. “Rigpa” means non-dual awareness.²⁶

The heart of the empirical psychology of DzogChen is its descriptions of the experience of knowing, or being, these two different modes of self awareness. In addition, the DzogChen theory of “gzhi” describes the differing origins of these two modes of self awareness,²⁷ and the DzogChen theory of “self liberation,” or “rangdrol,” describes the process by which the egocentric mind is transformed into egoless mind.²⁸

Having said all of this, the present paper is not a paper about DzogChen. It is not a paper that purports to present and/or analyze the DzogChen view or DzogChen meditation. Nor is it a paper that attempts to evaluate the psychological effects of DzogChen meditation. This is a paper about the phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness—the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind.

Why, then, is this paper drawn from research that has been done on DzogChen lamas? The answer is this: DzogChen mind science, more than any other school of Buddhist or western psychology, is a comprehensive descriptive and theoretical science of the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind.

As a result, DzogChen lamas are more than familiar with these phenomena. They have read about them, and they have experienced them in their meditation. This makes it possible to directly interview DzogChen lamas about their experiences of these phenomena. In our research, we have focused on the task of empiricizing the technical terms of DzogChen mind science by trying to find and describe the exact experiences to which they refer.

Here, then, is a partial list of some of the dialectical phenomena of the mind that have been delineated by DzogChen mind science. Each of the phenomena is first

²⁶DzogChen mind science abounds in synonyms. Of relevance here, the egocentric mode of self awareness is also known as “nyi-dzin rangrig”—which means dual self awareness. In addition, the egoless mode of self awareness has two important synonyms: (a) “nyi-may rangrig”—which means nondual self awareness; and (b) “rangrig yeshe”—which means wisdom self awareness.

²⁷The theory of “gzhi” is the DzogChen theory of self awareness, and it is a theory that is not found in any of the other schools of Buddhist thought. For a concise and accurate presentation of this theory, please see the chapter entitled “How Samsara and Nirvana Originated” in *The Practice of DzogChen* [20, p. 209]. For an empirical rendering of this theory, please see the chapter entitled “Predual Meanings: Gzhi Nang” in Volume III of *The Healthy Mind Interviews* [9].

²⁸A brief introduction to the notion of self liberation will be presented in the Appendix.

named in Tibetan,²⁹ and then they are described and defined in English by taking recourse to the terms used in the typology of dialectical phenomena presented in the main body of this paper.³⁰

1. *Shespa gyud*: The involuntary stream of consciousness.
2. *Yulchen*: The dual awareness, or watcher, that is the subject of egocentric self awareness.
3. *Rigpa*: The nondual awareness that is the subjective aspect of egoless self awareness. Rigpa is referred to as empty awareness in this paper.
4. *Gzhi-nang*: the primordial meaning that the mind gives to any given experience. In the terminology of this paper, a gzhi-nang is called an “individual MoC.” A gzhi nang is neither a dual nor nondual meaning.³¹
5. *Rnam-togs*: Individual thoughts that are dual inner appearances.
6. *Nyon-mon*: Individual emotions that are dual inner appearances.
7. *Bakchaks*: An inner narrative that is a recurring and habitual pattern of thoughts and emotions. These stories are created by the ego for the purpose of supporting its sense of identity. Depending upon context, the bakchaks have been called either mind films or recurring ego narratives in this paper.
8. *Doorwa*: The repression, or rejection, of a meaning that appears in the stream of consciousness.
9. *Lahngwa*: Holding onto, or attaching, a meaning that appears in the stream of consciousness.
10. *Jaysoodrong*: The act of believing and thus living in an ego narrative that has been created by a mind film. The term jaysoodrong is usually translated into English as “following.”
11. *Lahngdoor-maypa*: A state of mind in which awareness neither rejects nor accepts the meanings that appear in its stream of consciousness. This is one of the defining characteristics of empty awareness, or rigpa.
12. *Jaysoodrong-maypa*: A state of mind in which awareness does not follow the meanings that appear in its stream of consciousness. This is another of the defining characteristics of empty awareness, or rigpa.
13. *Nang-kyi-nangwa*: This term means inner appearance, and it refers to all of the different types of phenomena that appear in the stream of consciousness. That would include dual, nondual, and predual appearances.
14. *Talwa*: The instantaneous dissolution of a nang-kyi-nangwa.

²⁹The Tibetan terms in this list are spelled phonetically and are not transliterations of the Tibetan terms.

³⁰Once again, traditional Tibetan descriptions of these phenomena can be found in any number of DzogChen texts. See, for example, [20-25]. The best traditional introduction to these phenomena, both because it is clear and comprehensive, can be found in *The Practice of DzogChen* [20]. For discussions in which the traditional descriptions of these phenomena are empiricized in the language of modern social science, please see the four volumes of *The Healthy Mind Interviews* [9, 10, 26, 27].

³¹For an empirical discussion of the gzhi nang, please see the chapter entitled “Predual Meanings: Gzhi Nang” in Volume III of *The Healthy Mind Interviews* [9].

15. *Chosnyid*: A nondual inner appearance. It is nondual, or egoless, in the sense that it is a meaning that is empty of the conceptual overlay that egocentric awareness projects onto the phenomena it knows.
16. *Togpai Yeshe*: This is a moment of egoless wisdom, or knowledge, and it arises when rigpa has nondual awareness of either a primordial or dual meaning. It has been called a realization in the terminology of this article.³²

DzogChen mind theory, in keeping with the norms of the scientific method, is derived from its descriptive science of the dialectical phenomena of the mind. Three of the principal theories of DzogChen mind science are, once again, that:

1. there are two modes of self awareness;
2. a healthy mind is an egoless mind, given the paradox that you have to have an ego to be egoless; and
3. the egocentric mind is an unhealthy mind that suffers.

A fourth principle theory of DzogChen mind science is the theory of *self liberation*.³³ Self liberation is a technical term in DzogChen mind science, and it refers to the process by which the thoughts and emotions of the egocentric mind are transformed into egoless mind. The cultivation of self liberation is the defining dynamic of DzogChen meditation, and it is this dynamic that makes DzogChen meditation different than the other forms of Buddhist meditation.

From the perspective of DzogChen, meditations that cultivate self liberation are different than other meditations because they do not cultivate a predefined state of mind.³⁴ They operate on the premise that if you leave your stream of consciousness in its natural state, it will naturally and spontaneously transform itself into egoless mind—like a snake spontaneously slipping out of its own knots. This is the phenomenon of self liberation.

In contrast, the other schools of Buddhism practice meditation techniques that work on the very different premise of cultivating a predefined state of egoless mind. For example, if you were to define the egoless mind as being a mind in which thoughts do not appear, as many buddhist traditions do, you would then practice a meditation technique that cultivated a state of mind in which there is a cessation of thoughts.

To better understand the process of self liberation, it will be helpful, for a moment, to quickly revisit the DzogChen notion that the human mind has two modes of self awareness. Once again, these two types of self awareness are simply two different modes of relationship between the watcher and the stream of consciousness.

³²For a thorough empirical discussion of togpai yeshe, please see the chapters entitled “Rigpa and Yeshe” and “Nondual Meanings: Primordial Wisdom” in Volume III of *The Healthy Mind Interviews* [26].

³³Self liberation is a translation of the Tibetan term “rangdrol.”

³⁴To be more precise, in the language of DzogChen, this is presented as the notion that DzogChen meditations do not use dual mind, or sems, to cultivate a predefined state of mind.

To be very brief, the egocentric mode of self awareness is a dialectical process in which the watcher is forever and always trying to: (a) change the content of the meanings that appear in its stream of consciousness; and (b) control their expression. The egocentric watcher carries on this work of trying to control its stream of consciousness for the purpose of maintaining its sense of its identity.

In contrast, the egoless mode of self awareness leaves the stream of consciousness in its natural state. The egoless watcher does not alter its stream of consciousness in any way. To be more specific, this means that it does not repress, attach or follow any of the meanings that it knows. As a result, there is no dialectic, if you will, between the awareness and stream of consciousness of the egoless mind.³⁵

The import of allowing the mind to remain in its natural state is that when the stream of consciousness is allowed to pursue its natural course, it spontaneously and effortlessly transforms itself into the awareness and meanings of the egoless mind. Once again, this spontaneous transformation is the process that is called self liberation by DzogChen mind science.

In summary, then, DzogChen mind science is a descriptive and theoretical science of the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind. It differs from the western tradition of dialectical mind theory in two fundamental ways:

1. DzogChen mind science has developed, over the centuries, a comprehensive descriptive science of the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind. The dialectical mind theory of DzogChen is, in its turn, derived from this descriptive science. Western psychology, in contrast, has not yet produced a descriptive science of the dialectical phenomena of the mind. It has, nonetheless, developed a very important body of dialectical mind theory, but this body of theory has not been derived from the direct observation of the dialectical phenomena and processes of the mind. Western theory has, once again, been derived from the observation of: (a) dreams; (b) psychiatric symptoms; (c) the transferential phenomena of theory; and (d) the phenomena of childhood development.
2. Western dialectical mind theory acknowledges the existence of but one mode of self awareness: the egocentric mode. In contrast, DzogChen mind science acknowledges the existence of two modes of self awareness: an egocentric mode and an egoless mode. In keeping with this larger analysis, the DzogChen tradition has developed an applied science, if you will, that transforms egocentric self awareness into egoless self awareness.

³⁵Once again, for a more thorough discussion of the defining characteristics of these two modes of self awareness, please see the Introductions to both Lopon Tenzin Namdak's interviews and Lopon Tekchoke's interviews in Volume IV of *The Healthy Mind Interviews* [10]. For a systematic discussion of the states of mind generated by these two modes of self awareness, please see the forthcoming paper "The Defining Characteristics of the Healthy Human Mind" [34].

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